

Perhaps this is shown even more plainly in the Jewish belief in *wicked spirits*, and in the pre-eminently Wicked One, Satan. We ought, however, to make a distinction here. *Satan* is a Hebrew word which means "opposer," "accuser." Before the exile the poetical idea had already arisen in Israel, that in the council of heaven, among "the sons of God"* who surrounded Jahveh's throne, there was a "Satan," who had taken upon himself the task of pleading the unfavourable interpretation of man's character, and therefore could be charged by Jahveh with the allotment of misfortunes to mankind. This is the part which Satan plays, as we know, in the introduction to the book of Job.† Here he is still a servant of Jahveh, just as much as the other angels, and undertakes to carry out Jahveh's will. But the task which is given him is in accord with his nature, as expressed in the name which he bears. In the vision of Micaiah ben Imelah‡ all angels may equally aspire to carry out Jahveh's decision respecting Ahab's fall, and, in reply to a question addressed to all, "the spirit" (of prophecy) volunteers to perform the task; the poet of the Jobeid knows one among those heavenly beings who is marked out, as it were, for such punishments.—If we now open the prophecies of Zechariah, we find Satan still drawn there almost as he is drawn in the book of Job. He stands opposite Jahveh's throne, on the right hand of the high-priest Joshua, to accuse the latter.§ There is this amount of difference, that in this prophet Satan receives a rebuke on account of his attack on Joshua and on Jerusalem, so that he is already beginning to oppose Jahveh more than in the book of Job.|| It would be hazardous to see the influence of the Persian notion of Anro-mainyus¶ in this small modification, were it not that the Jewish Satan subsequently acquired the traits of this spirit of darkness more and more: now there is nothing strange in the idea that the

* Ps. xxix. 1; lxxxix. 7; Gen. vi. 2, sqq.

† Job i. ii.

‡ 1 Kings xxii. 19-23.

§ Zech. iii. 1.

|| Verse 2.

¶ Comp. concerning him Tiele, l. c., pp. 186, seq.